

What Is Known and Not Known: An Honest Evidence Brief for Hackles

The Hackles Kit

Trust your hackles. Pause · Check · Tell.

FIELD COPY



PLATE I. The six strands, hand-inked, in the order the lessons take them.

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OCTOBER 2026

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Built only from the kit's own evidence files (evidence_and_threats.md, the Round 1 Fact-Check Report, the Teacher Academy modules, the Assessment Pack and the Florida crosswalk). No study is cited here that the kit does not already cite. Where the kit marks a claim [VERIFY], this brief does too. Date of the kit's checks: 2026-10-05.

No student accounts, no student data collected, ever.

01 The short version

- **No controlled trial of Hackles exists.** The kit says so in the Assessment Pack, Academy Module 1, Academy FAQ 20 and the evidence file. Hackles has not been evaluated in a trial, has no pilot outcome data in the kit, and has not been reviewed or approved by any state agency.
- **What the kit rests on** is general prevention science: active, skill-based, repeated lessons appear better supported than one-off assemblies, fear appeals or information-only lessons. Much of that evidence comes from an adjacent field (school-based child sexual abuse prevention), not from online safety directly. [VERIFY the central review, Finkelhor and colleagues 2021, before quoting it.]
- **The threat numbers are real but they are not outcome evidence.** Counts of reports (NCMEC, FBI IC3) and survey shares (Thorn, Pew, Common Sense) tell us how large the problem looks. They do not tell us whether any curriculum reduces it.
- **The kit's own surveys measure knowledge, skills and confidence.** They can show a change in students' answers. They cannot show cause, behavior under real pressure, or lasting effects, and they have no reported validity evidence.
- **Anyone who says Hackles "prevents" a harm is overstating.** The honest claim is: "More students said they would tell a trusted adult after the lessons."

02 How to read the status labels

LABEL	MEANING IN THIS BRIEF
[VERIFIED 2026-10-05]	The kit's check read the primary source on that date. Pages change; confirm again before you quote
[VERIFY]	The kit has not confirmed it from a primary source. Treat it as a lead
Adjacent evidence	Evidence from a related field, applied by analogy
Not known	No evidence in the kit either way. It does not mean the answer is no

03 What is known and what is not

3.1 WHAT KIND OF TEACHING WORKS

QUESTION	WHAT THE KIT REPORTS	WHAT IS NOT KNOWN
Are active, skill-based, repeated lessons better than one-off lectures?	The Finkelhor, Walsh, Jones, Mitchell and Collier (2021) review in <i>Trauma, Violence, & Abuse</i> is the most-cited source. As summarized in the kit, programs that are structured, repeated and skill-based are better supported than one-off assemblies [VERIFY citation and read the full text]. The kit adds that a meta-analysis of 24 school-based sexual-abuse prevention evaluations shows gains in knowledge, protective behaviors and disclosure. That is adjacent-field evidence	Whether the same gains hold for online safety lessons, and for Hackles lessons in particular. How large any gain is. How long it lasts
Do information-only lessons work?	The kit reports that the review found 16 lessons from four internet safety programs mostly failed to meet basic prevention-education standards	Which specific features of those lessons mattered
Do fear appeals backfire?	The general fear-appeal literature is mixed; fear can backfire when people cannot act on it. Direct evidence for online safety is thin. The kit tells teachers not to say fear appeals are "proven to backfire" in this field [VERIFY]	The size and direction of any effect for children in online-safety lessons
Do privacy rules alone ("never share personal information") protect children?	A critique exists of teaching privacy rules as a standalone safety strategy [VERIFIED 2026-10-05 for the abstract only; the critique is of messaging mismatches, not of privacy rules as such]	Whether privacy rules plus a tell-a-trusted-adult skill do better. No trial in the kit
Does targeting behaviors rather than technologies help?	eSafety (Australia) argues for it, since platforms change faster than curricula [the site was not reachable by the kit's checker: VERIFY]	No outcome study in the kit

3.2 HELP-SEEKING AND SHAME

QUESTION	WHAT THE KIT REPORTS	WHAT IS NOT KNOWN
Is shame a barrier to telling?	The kit treats shame as the biggest obstacle and cites sextortion research where victims commonly cite shame. Thorn (2025) reports 1 in 7 victims driven to harm themselves [VERIFIED 2026-10-05]. The specific qualitative study on tone was not identified; the kit calls the shame-free tone a design choice	Whether a shame-free message changes the likelihood a child tells. No trial in the kit
How many children do not tell?	The kit quotes UNICEF Disrupting Harm: about one-third of children who experienced online sexual exploitation and abuse told no one, and about 3 percent told police or a helpline, in the first 13 countries (Africa and Southeast Asia). Discrepancy to resolve: Module 1 marks this VERIFIED, but the Round 1 report could not find those figures on the project page and left the flag [VERIFY in the country reports]. The figures are not US figures	The US picture. Whether lessons raise telling rates
Do disclosures go up after lessons?	The Assessment Pack says disclosures often go up after lessons because students feel safer, and that an increase is not a failure. No study is cited for "often." [VERIFY before repeating as a finding.] It is plausible and common in practice reports, but the kit gives no evidence	How often, how large, and whether it reflects trust or a change in reporting

3.3 PEER NORMS, DOSAGE AND DELIVERY

QUESTION	WHAT THE KIT REPORTS	WHAT IS NOT KNOWN
Does correcting misperceptions ("most teens would help a friend") help?	The social-norms literature supports the idea in general. The kit found no rigorous online-safety-specific trial [VERIFY]	Effect in this field
Does dosage matter (ten lessons across a year versus one)?	The design principle in the kit is multi-session, repeated yearly, with teacher and family touchpoints (a synthesis, partly inference)	The minimum effective dose. Whether ten 15-minute lessons are enough
Does teacher preparation change delivery or outcomes?	The kit has no evidence about teacher training effects. The Academy and Facilitator Kit are designed on the same principles (practice, role-play, shame-free language) but are not evaluated	Whether trained teachers teach better, handle disclosures better, or get better student outcomes. Unknown
Does the Hackles routine (Hackles up? Pause. Check. Tell.) help children?	The routine is the kit's own design. No trial	All of it

3.4 HOW BIG AND HOW NEW THE THREATS ARE (CONTEXT ONLY)

THESE NUMBERS JUSTIFY THE topic. They are not evidence that any curriculum works.

FACT	SOURCE AND STATUS
More than 50,000 reports of financially motivated sextortion in 2025 (about 137 a day), up from more than 36,000 in 2024	NCMEC [VERIFIED 2026-10-05]. The kit gives counts, not a percentage, because a "37 percent rise" could not be found on the primary pages
1.4 million online enticement reports and 21.3 million CyberTipline reports in 2025; more than 800 reports in which an offender traveled	NCMEC [VERIFIED 2026-10-05]

FACT	SOURCE AND STATUS
More than 75,000 sextortion submissions to IC3 in 2025; more than 5,700 involving minors referred to NCMEC	FBI IC3 2025 report [VERIFIED 2026-10-05, text read]
About 1 in 5 young people aged 13 to 20 reported a sextortion experience (1,200 surveyed); 44 percent of victims said images were recorded or screenshotted; 13 percent were threatened with an AI-generated deepfake nude	Thorn 2025 [VERIFIED 2026-10-05]
1 in 17 teens reported deepfake nudes created of them; 1 in 8 knew someone targeted	Thorn [VERIFIED 2026-10-05]. "1 in 25" is the UNICEF figure for some countries
At least 1.2 million children in 11 countries had images manipulated into sexual deepfakes in the past year	UNICEF/ECPAT/INTERPOL, 4 Feb 2026 [VERIFIED 2026-10-05; international]
64 percent of US teens say they use AI chatbots (about 3 in 10 daily); 72 percent had used AI companions at least once; about one in three companion users discussed serious matters with an AI instead of a person	Pew, Dec 2025 [VERIFIED]; Common Sense, July 2025 [VERIFIED for these figures; "a quarter shared personal information" and the sample size need the full report: VERIFY]
More than one in six high school students were bullied electronically in the past year	CDC [VERIFIED 2026-10-05 for the sentence; the all-student percentage in the YRBS tables was not confirmed: VERIFY before quoting a number]
Consumers reported losing \$3.5 billion to imposter scams in 2025	FTC, June 2026 [tagged verified in the evidence file; the Round 1 report lists FTC figures as not re-checked: VERIFY]

A caution on reading these: reports (counts) and surveys (shares) are different kinds of numbers. A rise in reports can reflect more harm, better reporting, or both. Most young people use technology without serious harm.

3.5 MEASUREMENT OF HACKLES OUTCOMES

QUESTION	WHAT THE KIT REPORTS	WHAT IS NOT KNOWN
Are the Assessment Pack surveys valid and reliable?	The pack presents them as classroom check-ins on knowledge, skills and confidence, with a Tell-Readiness indicator. It reports no reliability or validity evidence	Internal consistency, test-retest, validity against behavior, differences across groups
Can they show the program caused change?	No. Without a comparison group a change may reflect maturation, other lessons, news, repeated testing or chance	Anything about cause
Do answers reflect behavior?	The pack warns that students may give the "right" answer to please the teacher and that surveys capture what students say they would do	The link between stated intentions and behavior under real pressure
What about long-term effects?	The pack suggests an optional delayed post survey at 4 to 8 weeks	Whether skills last a year
What about small classes?	With fewer than about 20 matched students, percentage changes can swing; one child in a class of 24 is about 4 points	How to pool small classes best (see the study design menu)

3.6 WHAT THE KIT SAYS ABOUT ITS OWN STATUS

STATEMENT	WHERE
"We do not yet have a rigorous trial of a modern K-12 curriculum on topics like sextortion and deepfakes."	Academy FAQ 20; Module I
"We are not aware of a rigorous trial of a curriculum like this one." [VERIFY: confirm no such trial exists at the time of publication]	Assessment Pack Section 13
Hackles "has not been reviewed, approved or endorsed by" the Florida Department of Education or any Florida school district; no outside reviewer has seen the Plus lessons	Florida crosswalk
The Hackles-Ready certificate is honor-system and does not mean certification by any government or accrediting body	Academy Certificate and Badges

04 What kinds of evidence would answer the open questions

RUNG	DESIGN	WHAT IT CAN TELL YOU	WHAT IT CANNOT
1	Descriptive pre/post in one class	Whether answers changed	Why
2	Pre/post with a comparison group (for example, a delayed-start class)	Whether change exceeded what happened without lessons in the same window	Behavior; long-term; hidden differences between groups
3	Stepped wedge (every class gets lessons in steps)	Change over time with each class as its own control, and fairer to all classes	Same limits; needs more terms of data
4	Cluster randomized trial across schools	A causal estimate of effect on survey outcomes	Needs many classes or schools, partners and funding
5	Follow-up with observed skills (role-play rubric) and help-seeking records	Skill transfer and tell-readiness	Rare harms are hard to measure and ethically hard to ask about

OUTCOMES CLIMB A LADDER too: knowledge, then confidence and intention, then observed skill, then actual help-seeking, then harm. The kit's surveys sit on the first two rungs.

05 Gaps the kit itself lists

FROM THE EVIDENCE FILE (Section 5) and the Round 1 report:

- Not every primary report was opened in full. The IC3 report text was read; the Round 1 checks for Thorn and IWF figures used the organizations' web pages, and the Common Sense full report was not opened.
- No rigorous trial of a modern K-12 sextortion or deepfake curriculum was found.
- State-law lists and citations need counsel review; laws changed in 2025 and 2026.
- Unverified in Round 1: tips.fbi.gov and 1-800-CALL-FBI as channels; reportfraud.ftc.gov details; the CFAA statute text; reporting timelines for any state; UNICEF "one-third told no one"; IWF year-on-year claims;

Common Sense "a quarter shared personal information"; CDC all-student bullying percentages; FTC Consumer Sentinel figures; passkey adoption claims; many Concepts Lab historical details; CCSS, AASL, ASCA and state standards codes.

- Not attempted in Round 1: the CC BY-NC license wording, HACKLES trademark clearance, ADA Title II dates, parent-notification statutes and clinical or child-protection statements (reviewer sign-off items).

06 **How to say it (a language guide)**

SAY	DO NOT SAY
"No controlled trial of Hackles exists."	"Research shows Hackles works."
"The kit is built on principles from prevention science, mostly from an adjacent field."	"Hackles is evidence-based" (without saying what that means here)
"More students said they would tell a trusted adult."	"Hackles prevents sextortion."
"Reports of this kind of threat rose from more than 36,000 to more than 50,000 between 2024 and 2025 (NCMEC)."	"Sextortion is up 37 percent."
"Disclosures often rise after lessons, according to the kit's own note, which cites no study [VERIFY]."	"More disclosures prove the program works."
"This is a small study with no comparison group."	"This proves the program is effective."
"Hackles has not been reviewed or approved by any state agency."	"State-approved," "aligned with state law" (without saying it was mapped by the author and not reviewed)

07 **What to do with this brief**

- Put the "What is known and not known" table in any grant, IRB protocol or manuscript that describes Hackles.
- Use the study design menu to choose the strongest design your site can support.
- Re-verify the [VERIFY] items before quoting them. Update this brief when new primary sources are read, and date every update.
- If you add a study, add only what you have read in the primary source, with its limits.

This brief is educational guidance, not legal advice.